FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

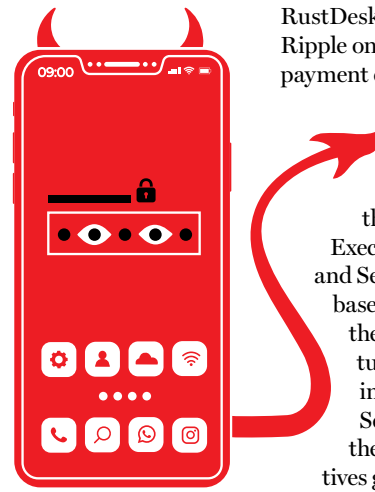
Dialling customer support can be a tiresome chore where one has to stoically bear wading through a maze of number keys, beeps and automated messages before the job gets done, if you are lucky. One never expects to enter a digital rabbit hole where you lose your way and your money. But this is one of the means through which literally tens of thousands of Indians are being duped across the country. At the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal's '1930' helpline, there were 700,000 complaints just in April 2023. That's 23,000 crimes a day. And victims can be found as far out as the Andaman and Nicobar Islands.

The damage they are inflicting on unsuspecting Indians is not small. The volumes involved in just credit and debit card fraud are going up like a booming stock—the RBI estimates it at Rs 119 crore, Rs 155 crore and Rs 276 crore for the past three fiscal years. And that's likely only the visible tip of the iceberg. For an average fraudster, taking a 10 per cent commission for every job as one tier of a multi-layered syndicate, it would likely seem a fair return on investment. For, he has actually spent on learning his craft at any one of the 'training centres' thriving across India. Crash courses in cybercrime are being offered for as little as Rs 15,000. That's how evolved and organised the racket is now.

It is not only common folks who are victims, but also well-known ones. Just days ago, DMK MP Dayanidhi Maran lost Rs 99,999 via a net banking heist pulled off with no OTP on his linked mobile phone. And actor Aftab Shivdasani was psyched into entering confidential bank details on a dodgy link by a threat of account suspension from an unknown number. Damages: Rs 1.5 lakh. Back in 2021, Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal's daughter Harshita fell prey to a reselling portal fraud while trying to sell a sofa. Actress Shabana Azmi and comedian Johnny Lever were led down the garden path by a fake wine-selling portal. The presence of famous people on the list of victims only shows how alarmingly routine digital fraud has become.

Who are these cyber crooks? Think of them as the bank robbers of our times. Just that they don't hit brick and mortar banks, their weapons are 'phishing' tools, and their faces are covered by sophisticated digital masks. Nor are they some disembodied web of bots. They are flesh and blood people from real social landscapes that are, surprisingly, far from our smart cities and local silicon valleys. The backward Jharkhand district of Jamtara, which gained notoriety as the 'phishing capital of India' a decade ago, has graduated to high-value frauds. But there are new Jamtaras, in equally unlikely places. The 'Mewat gang', striking from the impoverished trijunction of Haryana, Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh, leans towards social media swindles, reselling frauds and sextortion. Cyber gangs also have physical bases in Odisha, Bengal, Bihar, Karnataka, Assam, Gujarat and the seamier parts of metros like Delhi. That doesn't make tracking individual cases easy. They have a variety of means to cover their tracks: pre-activated SIM cards floating around with ties to no real identity, calls made from disguised numbers using servers abroad, Jan Dhan accounts with a hazy KYC trail or mule accounts to receive the stash and then make a dash.

A fake delivery leading to a fake customer care number is just one among the myriad of ruses they use. The old-fashioned confidence tricksters are still very much in the game, except nowadays it's called 'social engineering' because of where they approach the prey. From Facebook to Instagram, Twitter (now X), LinkedIn, YouTube, WhatsApp and Telegram, cyber crooks permeate the entire social networking universe. There could be inducements coming your way more impersonally: a lottery win, a job, an offer of easy money for online reviews or YouTube likes. Or threats, even as banal as that for electricity disconnection. Things get more menacing with AI and cloning techniques like deepfake, at whose most pernicious end lurk sextortion tools like DeepNude.



The critical moment in the hunt is when the kill happens. Here, most routes converge on one destination: getting hands on the victim's bank account details, passwords, OTPs and PINs. 'Social engineers' can sweet-talk you into divulging the vital information. Most others send across an innocuous-looking link that will either insert a Trojan malware that can read your phone or instal a remote access/ screensharing app such as Anydesk, RustDesk, ISL Light, Team Viewer or Remote Ripple on it. You are then lured into making a token payment online via, say, Paytm or net banking so as to lift the PIN or password. Then it's just a quick job at any ATM operated from a mule account. Yet others get you to scan a QR code that debits money the wrong way—away from your account. Executive Editor Manisha Saroop in New Delhi and Senior Editor Amitabh Srivastava, whose base in Patna gives him an old familiarity with the Jamtara phenomenon, describe this disturbing byproduct of India's digital revolution in its full span for our cover story this week. Senior Editor Pradip R. Sagar buttresses the narrative with national data and perspectives gleaned from the Union home ministry and senior police brass. The cyber police, whose numbers are as inadequate as the laws that back them, are finding it hard to keep up with this fast-morphing foe, especially after the arrival of AI with its ability to clone everything from profile pictures to websites to people's voices. They are trying to tackle the root of the problem. They are deactivating dubious phone numbers so as to eliminate fake SIM cards, for one. And also neutralising the potential danger of stolen phones being put to mischief by blocking their 'IMEI' numbers—a unique numeric code that identifies each individual device, much like a car's chassis number. Surveillance is tightening, with AI now integrated into subscriber base verification and the government launching Sanchar Saathi. In two years, DoT had identified 4.1 million dubious connections.

However, the primary capital for this industry is the target's gullibility. The victims are often the elderly, but certainly not exclusively. So, from banks to police, awareness-creation has become a mission. We join that mission, laying out case studies detailing the ways in which you can be defrauded. It's a list you do not want to join—that primer, therefore, will be useful for all. Be forewarned and be safe!



(Aroon Purie)

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